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Lou Pallo

Guitarist Lou Pallo has performed with a long and diverse list of artists in a career that now spans five decades. He currently performs throughout the New York/New Jersey area and can be seen at the Iridium on Monday nights with Les Paul. Lou's latest CD is called "Candy Box."

Lou was interviewed in New York City on January 14, 2007 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and we are in Manhattan filming for the Jazz Archive at Hamilton College and I'm really pleased to have a man of a million inversions, Lou Pallo, with me. Thank you for coming today.

LP: Thank you for inviting me.

MR: You know I went through your list of people you've played with. I think I found one person you didn't play with — Buddy Bolden.

LP: You're right, yeah, you're right.

MR: I'm like pretty much in awe of the number of people that you're shared the stage with and, boy, was there a moment or a time when you were a kid when you determined that you were going to be a professional musician?

LP: Not really determined it but I really loved music when I was a kid and I was doing many things. I was of course in high school taking guitar lessons, I was doing electronics, I was going to electronic school, radio and television, and I think — oh airline — something with the airlines. My father says, "You can only do one thing." So then I went just with the guitar. I stayed with the guitar lessons.

MR: Was yours a musical household that would steer you in that direction?

LP: My father played a little guitar, played in the back yard when they had the get-togethers, he played the open chords, the G and the C and the G7.

MR: Yeah. And sing?

LP: Everybody sang. It was a get-together every Sunday and they had mandolin players cause it was an Italian family. Every Sunday. So that's what made me really want to get into the guitar.

MR: Neat. What kind of songs would they have done?

LP: A lot of, well like "Mexicali Rose" — I don't know if you have ever heard that song.

MR: Sure.

LP: Oh you have, okay. A lot of waltzes, polkas, and a few standards, very few standards.

MR: Okay, but not just Italian songs then.

LP: No not just Italian but the standards and if they did play standards they didn't use all of the right chords, if you were playing all open chords, so instead of like using a C to a C diminished or a C sharp diminished to the D minor seventh to a G seventh, you would just play C and a G seven. You know, it would sound okay. It would.

MR: Sure. And the spirit was there.

LP: Oh yes, oh yes.

MR: How much in your guitar lessons over the years was valuable for when you started playing gigs? Let me rephrase that.

LP: Yes.

MR: Was there a lot of learning on the job for you?

LP: That's what I was going to get at, yes. Learning was on the job training, let's put it that way. You learn more playing with better musicians, that's number one, and you learn more that way than you can taking lessons. I mean taking lessons of course gives you the basic. But then once you're on a gig — as we call it, the gig — you'll see what one person has that you don't do and you'll pick up what he has and you'll see what the trumpet player's doing or the pianist or whatever, and it's better that way. That's what I was going to get at when you asked that question.

MR: Also on a gig is there a certain amount, for a young player, not learning only what and how to play but how to act? How to comport yourself? How to be a professional? Like you know, you don't necessarily hire the best player, you also hire people who are dependable.

LP: Yes. That's another thing to talk about. Yes. Maybe less of a musician but more dependable as you said. Sometimes that's even better. And so actually you learn from all of them, every one of them, and even from a lesser player, he might do something that you can pick up ideas from. There's always different ideas. I've heard standards where like we were talking about difference in changes and chords where you can, it comes back real smooth and so forth. A fellow who doesn't use that might come up with something, you say whoa, that sounded great, I think I'll try that. And you try it and then you could fit it in with yours and add it into your repertoire.

MR: Makes me think of a guitar player I played with once who was very self-taught and if he played a chord that was really great and I want to know what it is, and I'd say what is that and he'd show me his hand. You know?

LP: But he didn't know what it was.

MR: He didn't know what the notes were, he didn't know what it was, and I don't even think he could have told me the notes unless I had him play one at a time. But he was great. He had great ears.

LP: Oh well see that's what we were just talking about, great ears. It's like this gentleman came up and played San Francisco [sings] I left my heart in San Francisco. He'd say — we'll put it in C just make it easy — he would just go from C to G seven, instead of using the seven. It sounded pretty good though. And then of course he never played any of the flat fives or thirteenth or whatever. But at times it sounded so good that he said well it's not right but it's good. And I don't know how but it came out.

MR: Yeah, it came out.

LP: It sounded hillbillyish or — I don't mean to put that down — but it sounded more country. More country.

MR: Can you recall what your first paying gig was?

LP: Yes. Wow. I think first of all the union scale was seven dollars. I think it was seven or fourteen, something like that.

MR: Seven for what?

LP: For a gig.

MR: For the gig.

LP: That's what they gave us, seven dollars or fourteen.

MR: And what year would that have been?

LP: And I was like fourteen years old. 1952 maybe or somewhere around there. '50, '51. And it was with a four piece group and we had an accordion player. Accordion was very popular many, many years ago. And accordion, myself on guitar, a drummer and a trumpet player. And that was the first gig — professional gig I did. I remember that.

MR: And you were fourteen.

LP: I was about fourteen. I had to get working papers.

MR: Someone had to drive you to the gig?

LP: Yes. I had to have the working papers for the ABC, especially if you were working in a bar in those days. It was for the ABC and I remember doing that and it was fun.

MR: You said this could possibly be a career for me?

LP: Possibly.

MR: Possibly.

LP: It was a start and of course I wasn't playing what I play today, which you just keep adding and adding and you never stop learning. Like yourself, you said you could see chords and you'd say wow what was that. I'll probably play a chord and you'll look at it and say what is it? And I'll look at you and you'll play something and I'll say whoa, that sounded great.

MR: Yeah. Was there a turning point or a significant gig or a person that really made a difference early on for you. Can you point to a person or an event?

LP: A musician you mean?

MR: A musician.

LP: A guitarist let's say?

MR: Yeah.

LP: I really have to mention Tony Mottola, one of my favorites, besides Les Paul of course, who I work with. But Tony Mottola was the king to me. I just loved the way he played.

MR: He had the spectrum down.

LP: Yes.

MR: He could play.

LP: He could play anything, and may he rest in peace. He was a super, super, great guy.

MR: And was he a good reader?

LP: Yes.

MR: He had this, there was a nice sort of genre of instrumental music. I know my parents had his records, so I heard him growing up in the late fifties. It was sort of a very nice arranged thing featuring the guitar.

LP: Yes.

MR: And I sort of miss that these days.

LP: I do too. Because he would play chord melody, he'd play single note melody and of course he would play, if you listen to Johnny Mathis you'll hear the first thump— I don't know if Bucky Pizzarelli ever told you that — what we call the thump on the rhythm, and that's how Johnny Mathis' records, that was Tony Mottola playing rhythm. Unbelievable. Because guitar, if you play a record, we call a record, CDs today, when you played a record and you'll say, "Can you hear the guitar" to a layman. He'll say, "I don't hear a guitar." But in the background that rhythm guitar, like with Basie, that makes the whole thing. And Tony would play that so perfect. He was the first one to have that thump, and we call it a thump, where you don't actually hear the change but you do hear the change and it just fits with the rhythm section so pretty and so perfect.

MR: Is it a four thumps per measure or is it more of a two and four?

LP: It's according to if you're doing it on a two and then to a four. Exactly. Right. But I would say on a ballad you would hear it more on the two and four. And so listen to it with Johnny Mathis way back and you'll hear Tony Mottola in the background on that.

MR: Like "Chances Are?" That kind of tune?

LP: Yes. "Chances Are," every one he did, "Misty," all his first records he ever did. And then Bucky does the same thing now if you notice.

MR: How do you thump? I mean what is it that —

LP: Well first of all you don't use all six strings, you try to stay with the bottom strings, and you have to make sure, like even Bucky says it to me that you don't have to play — if a thirteenth comes up on your music you don't have to play the thirteenth, just play the

triad or whatever it is, and just make sure you do it, and it would be like in elevenths and more like that, and you don't even have to — if the trumpets are playing the thirteenths and all that it doesn't affect you at all because you're just playing the basic, the root, the fifth — make sure you get that in there.

MR: That's something that really needs to be told to young guitar players like in big bands, because I see these high school kids and they see the music and I see them trying to get all this stuff. And there no way — and not only can't they do it but they shouldn't because it doesn't sound right.

LP: No. No you don't have to because then you have the horn section doing that or the string section doing that, so, if you're going to play rhythm, if you are going to play rhythm. But how many are playing rhythm today though. That's, every guitar player, young guitar players want to get out there and play that lead and there are a few though, being with Les Paul I say three people a night, every Monday night, being with Les 23 years now, come up and say, "Gee I'd love to play rhythm guitar." And when you hear it from a youngster it makes me feel so good. It's not that — I love rock & roll too. I love all kinds of music. There's good and bad. But when they talk about rhythm that's real rhythm. It's the real stuff, back then.

MR: You could almost have a band without a drummer when you have that thing going like that.

LP: Exactly. That's why if I do a special job and I need a trio I'd rather use a bass player and no drums at all, maybe keyboard, bass and myself or a trumpet, bass and myself or whatever. And I'll be the drummer.

MR: You should get paid twice you know that.

LP: That'd be — you know you're right. I should get double fee. That's true.

MR: I can tell by the people you've played with that you don't discount much music that I can see, that you're prepared to play almost every kind of music that comes along.

LP: Yes.

MR: How did that happen? How do you prepare?

LP: As far as if I'm going to do a job that is out of my range?

MR: Well you've gone from Keith Richards to Tony Bennett. So —

LP: Well okay, all right, well it's basically the same except of course like Keith, that's another story, he is a great rock & roll player. A great rock & roll player. And when we get together I'll do my thing, he does his thing, and we usually do everything live and like in a circle, live microphones and I'll play my way of playing, he plays his way and it just sort of blends. It sort of really blends. Of course sometimes maybe I have to change a little bit if you're going to do a rock type thing. But most of the things I do with Keith are standards. We did a lot of standards. We did 16 CDs and I have them all home, of [sings]

I wonder who's kissing her now — songs like this. This is Keith Richards. We did "Over the Rainbow," "Nearness of You," songs like that. And he's learning from me and I'm learning from him. I'm actually learning from him too. And he's the first one that said here's a chord that you don't know. And he played it and I have it on CD where he is saying "I've got one Lou Pallo doesn't know." It's funny. And I'm looking at him and saying, "I know it." And he says, "No, you don't know this one." But it's cute though. It was just a triad.

MR: It was just a triad?

LP: It was a G B D let's say, it was a G B D but the way he put it, the way he formed it, I just don't play that version. But when I played it I looked at him and I said "hmm." And now I use it.

MR: That's great.

LP: I do use it once in a while. That's what we were just talking about, you learn from other people.

MR: I've always been sort of mystified by guitar, like when you put your hand halfway up the neck, are you — I'm not even sure how to say this — are you aware of every note you're playing all the time or is part of it a hand position thing?

LP: That's a good question. 'Cause you're right, you don't know all the time. There are a lot of changes I'll be playing so in other words what you're asking me is when I hit this right here, do I know what note this finger's on? No. You're right. But I do know the chord is either a sub to what I'm playing, that I do know. But I'm going to take notice of that. It's a very good question.

MR: Well I just — I play piano, and when you put your hands down you can see what you're playing. That's the way I think of it.

LP: You see what you're playing.

MR: You can see what you're playing as well as you probably know what you're playing. But I always felt like well guitar you don't have black and white notes that you can nail it really quickly.

LP: Right.

MR: And I watch guys like you and I watch Bucky and they're playing a million inversions and I've often been curious like do they know exactly what those things are — how do they know exactly what those things are?

LP: Oh all right. Anyway I'm just thinking about it when I do play because I do change every beat, but when I am playing, yes I know let's, we'll take a change, we'll take an A minor chord, I'm just moving one note maybe, so I already know what I'm playing, but I'm not paying attention to the exact note maybe is what you're saying. I know I'm doing a chromatic going down from A, A flat, G and so forth. But if you were to stop me and say

what was that third change you played I'd say oh wait a minute now let's get back to that one. You would stump me on it. But I only do that live. When you're doing recordings you really should stay on the change. If you're reading music and it says C for four bars, you stay on C for four bars. You don't play any substitutions because now if there's an arrangement you're going to interfere with the string section, horn section, whatever it is. So you do stay with it on recordings. But live it gets so boring staying on one change so I like to make the different substitutions.

MR: The guitar really became very important in pop music.

LP: Yes sure did.

MR: Just about good timing for you, don't you think?

LP: That's right, yes. And in the fifties is when they had like a guitar club where Tony Mottola was number one, Bucky was involved on that, Al Caiola and so many of them, Barry Galbraith, and whenever they had recording sessions that's the way it would go. Tony would be the first one called out and if he couldn't make it then it would be the next one, I forgot who was second but say Al Caiola or somebody, then Bucky and on down the line. And I got on a few of those, which was great because I was maybe the thirtieth down the line. There were so many. And I would have to replace like with Tony Hatch with —

MR: Petula Clark?

LP: Petula Clark. Okay. I had to do a rhythm section thing on that with Tony Hatch and Barry Galbraith was supposed to do it and then he called me and then I did it. So that was, and that was my first experience doing a recording session with strings. Oh —

MR: Heaven, huh?

LP: Heaven. And they were all, can I tell you about this?

MR: Please.

LP: Okay.

MR: That's why I'm here.

LP: The string section is in front of me in the studio and the violins, the cellos, and so on, facing me. And here I am with my music stand facing them. Next to me was another guitarist, I can't think of who was on that session, and I was playing a twelve string. I borrowed Les' twelve string guitar for that because I didn't have one. And I'm looking at the music, I'm turning the pages, all the string section, they're all reading the *New York Times*, reading the newspapers, waiting until you hear Tony Hatch come in and say, "Okay one, two, three," and they just put down the newspaper and they go [scats] and they read the score and they're reading notes like all the way down and here I am looking at the chart for a good ten minutes before they started the session. What readers they are.

And then just from the experience of the strings, what a chill down my spine listening to them right in front of you. It was a first experience with the strings, oh fabulous.

MR: That's a good story.

LP: Love it.

MR: Yeah I know, I've had that feeling too, like oh I want to get this right.

LP: And then of course I jumped from there to when I was with Al Caiola we did the Washington Symphony Orchestra with Doc Severinsen conducting. That was, that's a hundred pieces, is it a hundred pieces, or ninety-something piece orchestra. That was a thrill, being out front with Al, Al was on my left, I'm here, and we had an accordionist and Doc Severinsen in front of us conducting the symphony behind us. Oh, hearing those strings behind me. It was — I loved it, loved it.

MR: In the studio, those kinds of sessions, they expect you to do it correctly the first time if possible?

LP: Yes.

MR: Because it's a time thing, right?

LP: Exactly.

MR: And they don't want to have overtime.

LP: They're paying for the time.

MR: Do you recall if Petula Clark was even there?

LP: No she wasn't there. We were doing the rhythm.

MR: The tracks.

LP: The tracks for the rhythm section. And with not only rhythm, I'm sorry, the whole music background.

MR: Do you remember what the song was? Was it one of her hits?

LP: It was an original and I think "Born Free" might have been one of them. I'm not too sure. "Born Free," oh I can't think of the other one.

MR: Any other particular studio dates like that stick in your mind, people that you've recorded for?

LP: Oh there were so many. But the strings really get to me. That I have to say, that's great. And the other things of course with Keith and a lot of doowop type things, a lot of that where you're recording sessions, you just go in and play. And of course they couldn't write for guitar in those days, all they did was write the change and then if they wanted you to play a lead — maybe someone told you this — like in the fifties they never wrote for guitar, they just wrote the changes and they would say okay, take a lead here between these four measures and you'd have to change it and you'd play your own, what you wanted to play. And now they're writing for guitar.

MR: Oh they're writing out the solo parts?

LP: Well they have been in the past say ten years. But they never did write the actual single notes out for guitar.

MR: Did they get specific enough to say like let's do that again because we didn't like that lead you played?

LP: Oh yes. Yes. Yes.

MR: But you'd have to do the whole rhythm section probably, or did you do any overdubbing of just solo parts?

LP: Yes, but not on any big recordings I mean I'm trying to think of now, where I did like three parts. I generally did like three, four parts where it sounded more like a guitar section.

MR: Yeah. Three guitars. They can't all do the same thing, right?

LP: Right.

MR: So what is the, sort of the assignment of roles between those two or three guitar players? What is one person doing and the other person doing?

LP: Oh okay, I've done that too, for the Four Seasons. Again that's sort of like a rock group, we call that rock. We've had, I think there were four guitar players on that if I recall. Vinnie Bell. You've heard of Vinnie Bell I think? Vinnie was on it. There was someone, a young boy who was about 18 playing acoustic and Tommy DeVito, he was one of the Four Seasons. There was four guitarists. My part was just to play, not rhythm like big band style, just arpeggio type rhythms every — maybe in a measure you'd have the arpeggio type thing, you'd just strum down, then you would strum down, and then maybe play two beats here, one beat here. That they could write at that time. And it just gave color. Because you had so many other guitar players. And I think Vinnie played the same thing but not the same arpeggio in the same spot and the way it came together, we did quite a few of their records and I'm trying to remember, like "Tell it to the Rain," "I've Got You Under My Skin," and all those. We were on those, and a bunch of other ones.

MR: Was someone assigned to the, just the two and four?

LP: No they really didn't do it on that. Well just on the rock part if — yeah, what we used to call the chicks.

MR: The chicks, yeah.

LP: You recall that. Now you play piano?

MR: I'm a piano player.

LP: And you know about that?

MR: Well I'm a fan of that music and I like to listen to what the rhythm section is doing. And what's neat sometimes on those old — in fact some of the Four Seasons records — if you have stereo, the way they mixed them you can pan it all the way to one side or the other

and they used to put all the vocals on one side and the band is on the other. So you can really hone in on —

LP: Oh. I'll have to try that on some of the records I have.

MR: Yeah. It doesn't work for everything and in some of the remixes they didn't do that. But I'm talking about sometimes if you're listening to the oldies station in the car you know, try it.

LP: Oh you can do that there, okay.

MR: Sometimes you can say oh, that's neat.

LP: Because we did, if I recall on the Four Seasons recordings Frankie didn't even sing, Frankie Valli of course, and they didn't do their background, but they did put it on later on. He might have done a scratch track of the vocal if I recall that, he did that. And we did a lot of commercials too. In those days all the rock & roll groups and groups were doing commercials for different stations. Like, "Hi this is Frankie Valli for KTLM in Oklahoma City" and we would be playing in the background and then mix those up. We did a lot of those.

MR: How much did those, what was the studio rate at that time?

LP: On their studio rate I think about two-fifty, about two hundred and fifty dollars, for three hours.

MR: For three hours.

LP: Two-fifty for three. And then it went up and a lot of times of course you went overtime. And that was at Phillips Recording Studio which Bob Crewe was the producer I remember that. We did eight hours one day, I remember that, doing eight hours.

MR: It's a good day.

LP: It was a long day. That was a long day.

MR: Did you ever get in a situation where they said okay we're going to have to go over and you've got another gig to get to?

LP: Oh well they probably have, I don't recall any but I would have to leave.

MR: You'd have to leave.

LP: Yes. Or whoever, there were so many others that had to leave too. Especially Tony Mottola and Bucky, they would have, they would go studio to studio. They would get done with one session at one o'clock and two o'clock started another session at another studio. And they had amplifiers put in lockers. They all chipped in and bought amplifiers, they were the only ones that could use them. So I'd always bring my own amp. I wasn't in the clique in those days.

MR: I see. Yeah.

LP: And they would just take it out of the locker, boom they were ready. They were ready to play. It was good days. And we were talking about the chicks, like you were saying with

the guitars. One guitar player would just play the chicks on a two and four, and there wasn't any changes involved. That was playing the high string, and you could hear that. And again if you said to somebody "can you hear the guitar?" "I don't hear a guitar." But he's right there with the chicks. That was very big in the fifties and sixties. And then that went out and then of course they brought the strings in with the rock & roll and all of that, and that sort of went out now too. Now it's all —

MR: Did the producers like a certain kind of guitar? I mean did they want you on a Strat or did they get that specific?

LP: That, I've never been questioned on, as far as meaning when you went into the studio if you were a guitar player and I would bring a 175, ES 175 —

MR: Which is a what?

LP: A Gibson ES 175, Epiphone, I have the Epiphone also, and then I would bring a 335, which is a Gibson also. That I find the most, the best recording guitar was the 335. That's what Eric Clapton uses a lot. A 335. It's a great guitar. It's all around. But acoustic wise of course not, not for acoustic.

MR: Did they used to put mics in front of your amp or you went direct into the —

LP: A lot of them were the microphones in the beginning because they didn't even have the XLR's coming out in the back on all amplifiers. That was always high impedance and then that was noisy. But usually a mic in the front of the amp. I had a Twin amp, one of the first, I think 1958 or '59, I don't know when they first came out. They didn't have reverb on it. And I did a recording session with The Dinning Sisters. Now I know there's someone you never heard of.

MR: The Ding?

LP: Dinning.

MR: Oh the Denning.

LP: Dinning Sisters.

MR: Denning Sisters.

LP: Ginger was her name and she broke away from her two sisters and it was just myself and her and I brought this amp in and they put the mic in the front and he said it was the quietest amp he ever heard, the engineer, which was — because usually they always have a hiss or a hum, but that amp was quiet and I sold that amp. I'm sorry I ever sold that amp many years ago. I wish I still had it.

MR: How many guitars do you own now?

LP: Ooh. What do I have. Not that many. Not many because I like to play them all so every week I change and I'll bring each one in so I can play them. So I have approximately eight, nine, ten, somewhere around there. I have given a lot to my son that I don't use.

MR: That's neat. At least your guitars don't get so lonely, they don't get touched.

LP: Right. Never get lonely. I was always told that if you have an instrument you should play it and not just leave it in the case because then the neck tends to go on you after a while and so forth. You have to play it. You have to play all the instruments so I like to change.

MR: Have you always made a living as a musician?

LP: Not always but I would say the majority of my life, yes, the majority.

MR: And even when you weren't you were probably playing.

LP: I was still playing on weekends.

MR: Yeah.

LP: Right. I just — when I was first married I took a job, I was a production manager with *The New York Times* and it was in New Jersey, they had a subsidiary. And I did that for about three years and playing weekends and then the headaches started coming because of working so many hours as a production manager and the pressure, I said I'm going back to music. I went back into music and stayed in music since then.

MR: That's great. How would it come about that you would work with a guy like Slash?

LP: That is through Les, in other words like we're playing let's say at the House of Blues. We opened up almost every one of those. Slash would show up and then we would play in there. And then I played once with Slash in New York but I can't think of the name of the place now, right here in New York. And oh, names are going on me anyway, but I played with him here also in New York, without Les, that was another gig that we did. But of course he has his things and it's hard to play with Slash because he doesn't play changes. Not that I'm putting him down or anything.

MR: I understand.

LP: You know he'll play like a C minor blues and he stays on it, which is fine. So now you just fall into that. I was just thinking of someone else is the same way — well it'll come.

MR: What about backing up comedians? That must be a hoot.

LP: That's fun but you really don't play that much. You'll play the opener and sometimes some comedians do sing, and they give you the key, no arrangements, no charts, just play behind them. And once in a while of course the drummer has to be alert with a comedian with these —

MR: The fills.

LP: The fills and so forth. But you just stay on stage, like with Pat Cooper we would bring him out and he would come out and did his thing and then we'd play him out and you'd have to stay up there the whole forty minutes or an hour.

MR: Yeah, and hear some of the same jokes night after night.

LP: Right, the same jokes.

MR: I remember playing once with Connie Francis and some guy in the audience said, "We love you Connie." And we all thought that was such a nice thing. And the next night some guy in the audience goes, "We love you Connie," it was the same guy.

LP: Same guy? Oh that's great.

MR: Like a plant you know. So it's fun to watch that kind of showbiz.

LP: Oh sure. The best I think I have to say, talking about different people, Sammy Davis Jr. was one of the most fabulous entertainers in the world I think, as far as entertaining. He did everything. And playing with Sammy Davis, oh I have a good story for you. I only did one week with Sammy Davis and the music would be piled up this high, and we would rehearse the — George Rhodes I think was the orchestra that I played with. And we would have all the charts set for the show. Sammy would come out and start the show and they would change "What Kind of Fool Am I" to a different rendition. Now he had about five different arrangements of "What Kind of Fool am I." One was for T.V., one was for live, one is a short rendition or whatever. And I had the one we rehearsed. And now I'm going through this pile of music we did already and halfway through the song I'm looking for the song because they changed the chart, and to go through this music, you're fiddling through and Johnny Mendoza was the rhythm/percussion, and he says, "Lou, don't worry about it just play the other chart and then fake it." And that's what I had to do. Because the music was piled so high. And then playing for Sammy Davis the thing, I love a good entertainer and watching Sammy perform, it's hard to watch him and watch what your cues are going to be next. And I tried to watch, he was just fabulous, fabulous. And he played drums too. He came back, played drums. But he was great. A great entertainer.

MR: That is really hard to do, to keep your eye on the music when you're playing with some legend out there.

LP: And you're trying to see, because I'd rather be out in the audience watching him. I really would. But you can't, you have to pay attention to the chart.

MR: Do you get, I guess what the word might be, residuals or payments for your studio work that you did?

LP: No. All that was all flat fee, the studio work.

MR: You ever go in your car and some song comes on the radio and you say oh I'm on that.

LP: Very, very seldom because I don't listen to a lot of those stations. But every once in a while I'll hear it. I'll say oh yeah I remember that now.

MR: What do you listen to?

LP: In the cars that I've been leasing now have XM radio in them, and so we listen to a thing called "Frank's Place" which plays a lot of nice jazz things, they play John Pizzarelli and Ella Fitzgerald and stuff like that. And I still like to listen to standards, the standards from

the forties up, the real standards. They're just songs, written by songwriters before the musicians started writing songs. Not that musicians wrote bad songs but you know you had the Lerner and Loewe and all the other ones, they were all great songwriters.

MR: That's an interesting point you just made. The classic, the standards that never seem to die, like Rod Stewart can—

LP: Come out with—

MR: Three CDs full of these things, and most of those things were not written by performers.

LP: That's correct. Correct. It was all written by songwriters and that's all they did. I'm trying to think of them all but Irving Berlin and people like that. Irving Berlin played just the black keys I understand, is that right?

MR: I did hear that. I heard something about he only played in F sharp.

LP: That's right.

MR: But he had a piano built with some kind of lever on it.

LP: And he changed the keys?

MR: Yeah, it would move, literally move the hammers or some such thing.

LP: That's what I heard.

MR: I've heard that many times.

LP: Wow.

MR: That's interesting.

LP: They said he played the black keys.

MR: How could he write such great harmonies?

LP: I know, "White Christmas" and "I Lost the Sunshine," he wrote all those pretty songs he did, a lot of nice things. But the songwriters did write all the good songs from way back. Look at all the old musicals, with Jimmy Cagney, remember he did "You're a Grand Old Flag," I've forgotten who was the writer.

MR: Oh Cohen.

LP: All right Cohen, you know all them. "Night and Day," not Cohen but "Night and Day" all those pretty songs, they were all written by songwriters.

MR: Who, can you think of a songwriter that you like that works from the guitar? I mean most of those guys played the piano.

LP: That's right. And I can't remember the name now — Costa. Don Costa, who wrote a lot for Sinatra.

MR: He's a guitar player?

LP: Yes. He's a guitar player.

MR: I didn't know that.

LP: And he wrote a lot of great arrangements. That was one now you just mentioned, that's a guitar player that wrote a lot of arrangements and great arrangements. And it's just hard

to write because sometimes if I — going back when I did write some charts, you have your hand on here and you're here, and now you have to grab the pencil and you're doing this, and it's so hard, whereas a lot of pianists, as you play piano, you can go like this and you could write it down.

MR: Just logistically it's easier.

LP: But on the guitar it's so hard, because you have the pick in your hand too, so you have to use your thumb instead and then try to write. So it's kind of tough. But you get by on that. But Don Costa is the only one that I know of. I'll have to ask some of the guitar players that I know, and he did write some great arrangements for Sinatra.

MR: Have you ever had any physical ailments from years and years of that?

LP: Yes. Yes. Lately, the past two years I would say, where a finger, everything just cramps and I can't move them. It's not arthritis, I guess maybe from all the years. And even the pick hand, I'll be playing like this and all of a sudden this finger will go out like that and I can't control it. And I have to stop and try to do this. And like Bucky has the arthritis, Les has it, everyone has arthritis. I don't actually have bad arthritis but they do cramp and they get into a fixed position and I can't move them.

MR: Well you think of how many hours those hands spend doing that.

LP: Years and years of playing, Right. And here I thought it would be better because you're always using them. It should be helping.

MR: Think if Freddie Green had a penny for every chomp he did.

LP: Oh wow. He was fabulous. The guitar would be like this, did you ever see the way he played? That's why he was playing on the bottom string.

MR: Okay.

LP: If you notice, you see instead of like this he was hitting them like this.

MR: See I thought it was the top strings more. I knew he didn't play all the strings.

LP: Well you know, the lower.

MR: The lower strings. So on the other fingers he would sort of just deaden the other strings or you just don't hit them?

LP: You can deaden them. You deaden them. But it gives you that nice — without that with Basie, I mean no one can beat Freddie Green on that. But now that's a different — when you get a chance listen to Basie, then listen to Johnny Mathis with Tony. It's a little different. Tony's was more, you can hear the change more. And it's just fabulous with Tony. I think he used an L5 I'm pretty sure, where on Basie, I think he used a Gretsch, I think he played a Gretsch guitar, a big body Gretsch.

MR: There's a little anecdote about him when he had an amp for a while and he would want to take solos but the guys in the band kept sabotaging the amp. Because when he stopped

playing rhythm the band fell apart. So for the sake of the band the guys kept disconnecting the speakers.

LP: I never heard that.

MR: Yeah I read that in that Bill Crow. Have you ever seen that Bill Crow *Jazz Anecdotes*? Oh you'd get a big kick out of that.

LP: Oh all right. I'll have to write that down.

MR: Yeah it's got these little stories.

LP: That's cute, wow. Because I was wondering if he could, he probably could.

MR: He probably could have. I have one CD with him and Herb Ellis called "Rhythm Willie" where he plays a little bit. It's pretty nice.

LP: Oh. With Herb. Okay.

MR: He definitely, that was his thing. His stock in trade.

LP: I haven't seen Herb Ellis in many, many years.

MR: Yeah. He's still around.

LP: He's still around, God bless him. He was at Fat Tuesday's when we were there and that was in the eighties, yes in the eighties was the last time I saw him. He was the highest paid jazz guitarist on recording, I guess you know that, right?

MR: I didn't know that.

LP: Oh yeah at one point in eighty — I can't remember, in eighty-something. It was right in the magazines, who was paid the highest in what categories: rock, jazz. And Herb Ellis was on more jazz records, and wow.

MR: How did the association with Les Paul come about?

LP: Well that's — we were talking about that — my best mentor was Tony Mattola and Les Paul. When Les Paul came out I said wow that's, what a sound. Les lived in Mahwah, New Jersey and I'm in Pompton Lakes, New Jersey, which is like twelve miles difference, and after Les broke up with Mary he used to go out almost every night and I'd play five, six, seven nights a week — he would show up on all my gigs. That's how I met him.

MR: Really?

LP: And then he says, "Come on over to the house," so I went over to the house, we had a jam, we jammed together, and we would go out a lot. On whatever night I had off we would go out and that's how I got to know him and play with him, then he put me on some recording sessions at his studio in his house. We did a lot of recording sessions there and he decided well let's go out playing. And we picked up Monday nights at Fat Tuesday's and that's like 23 years ago. That's a long time ago. And we've been playing every Monday night since then. And he won't miss. He will not miss. It's good therapy.

Good therapy for everybody. And then he would come into the club where I'm playing and sit in with me three times a week.

MR: Gee that's great.

LP: People would see him and go, "Oh Les Paul's going to be there tonight, let's go." And he would just sit and I would play songs like "Proud Mary" because that's the type of place I was working in. Les would just play along with me. But of course now we're doing his thing.

MR: Right. Well after all, I was never quite sure, what exactly did he — he invented the Les Paul guitar? What exactly was it that he did for the guitar? Do you recall?

LP: Let's see. I know he does have a patent on the trapeze tailpiece, that's the bottom of the guitar. That he has a patent on. He did some innovation on, well the Les Paul guitar, more of a solid body, because he had what we call the railroad track, as he calls it, he put a string on the railroad track and the vibration of it and the sound of it sustains and so forth. That's where you come in with the solid body. And then with Gibson he worked with Ted McCarty and together they made the Les Paul guitar, and that was I think, I'm not too sure of the year. In the fifties is when the first one came out.

MR: Yeah. A pretty innovative guy, he did the stuff with the tape overdubbing.

LP: Oh that's another part yeah, that's the electronic part. And Les is still experimenting today. He still doesn't stop at 91 years old. He is always trying, puts the pick-up on top of the guitar, on the bottom and sideways, on angles, and tried everything. It's always, like we were just talking about music itself, you never stop learning. He'll never stop learning. And it's great too. It's great to keep learning. You just taught me something too, today, you told me about the piano.

MR: You've got a nice little group there too at the Iridium with —

LP: With Les, yes.

MR: And Nicki Parrott.

LP: Nicki Parrott's on bass, correct. And she is fabulous. We found her, well I saw her first and told Les, I said, "Les, I heard this female bass player." He says "aww, she can't play bass." I says, "Les, you have to hear her." So she came in and sat in with us on a couple of songs and he said whoa, he couldn't believe it. Because he figured it's a girl—

MR: Smaller hands.

LP: Because of her smaller hands and so forth, but she plays that acoustic bass. She's great. And then we hired her. She's been with us now like, I'm not too sure, five years maybe.

MR: Do you notice, is there any discernable difference in playing with an acoustic as opposed to an electric bass?

LP: Yes.

MR: What is the difference for you?

LP: For me I prefer the acoustic. And you could have it amplified of course but the acoustic of the bass still comes out. It has more bottom and warmer I would say. If you do play the electric bass you really have to get someone that really is playing the correct notes. Because now the notes are really going to be heard and popped out.

MR: That's true.

LP: They better play the right notes. And the right patterns. If you're going to walk with the bass and so forth. I think you can probably get away with it on an acoustic a little bit, but I'd rather work with the acoustic. It gives you a little more bottom.

MR: Did you ever have to play bass?

LP: Yes.

MR: You played electric bass?

LP: Yes. That's with Dion and the Belmonts. We were working this place and they were doing their show. The bass player I was working with couldn't read. So at that time I was good at reading bass clef so I took his Fender, I guess he had a Fender bass if I recall, and I played the bass part. That was the only time I played the bass. It was easy because the charts were very simple. It was playing on a one and three mostly or something like that, and I could read them off fast. And I played it with a pick on a bass 'cause boy, that hurts. When you do this on your fingers. But that's the only time I played a Fender just with that on one of the shows and I tried playing bass but it hurts my fingers number one, if you're going to use the right, correct way to play it.

MR: Right. Did you ever do any extended road work?

LP: Oh yes. I'd be out like maybe two months, that was like Vegas, Reno, Tahoe, on different tours, it was with a group called the Hi Lads and we would tour all over.

MR: Did you like it?

LP: It's fun playing in different venues and especially playing Vegas and all that because all you have to do is bring your guitar with you. You pick your amp out. They have a room full of amps you say, "I'd like that amp at four o'clock in the afternoon" whatever time you go on. They'd have it out there set up with the wire. You just plug in and you're all set. The controls would be all set for you. But living on the road after a while gets kind of rough. You have so many different clothes with you and so forth and you have to keep getting them cleaned because you can't bring too much with you. And it's lonesome in a way.

MR: There's a lot of down time, right?

LP: Lot of down time and traveling time, especially when you're driving from town to town. It's fun. It's an experience though.

MR: Yeah. It's something you should do but —

LP: I think it's something you should do, try it, and then like now if we go on the road we fly out on a Tuesday, we perform on Wednesday, we're back on Thursday, which is great. We'll do one night.

MR: And when you say we?

LP: Oh, oh well mostly with Les.

MR: Okay.

LP: And the longest I've been away with Les was when we did Spain, that was a week. We flew out, we did a whole week in Spain and then flew back after that. That was The Expo — all the guitarists from all over the world. That was a great show.

MR: I'll bet.

LP: A great show. But that's the most in the past twenty years I guess, that I was away.

MR: Any difference in playing overseas?

LP: No. You mean as far as performing?

MR: Audience reception.

LP: The reception you get overseas is fabulous, I mean the Europeans I guess, that's where we were, they just appreciate everything you do.

MR: What do you think of — here's a big question — but what do you think of the music scene today? You don't seem to have a lack of work. Right? You said before that work for you is not a problem.

LP: No problem at all. I have no problem. And like January is supposed to be the slowest month for musicians. And I've been turning jobs down. And I presume Bucky is too and other musicians. And there are some that say, "Gee I only have two gigs this month" or three or four or whatever. I have too many. I've been turning some down. Because I guess a lot of it has to do with what you were asking me, how do I go from one venue to another, like if I have to go with a rock band, I'll play with a rock band one night. The next night I may play with a trio that does Italian music let's say. Then the next night I might play with an Irish band. Oh and then I also work with Jimmy Sturr who has a big band, he has 14, or I think he has 15 Grammys now.

MR: The polka music.

LP: The polka guy. But I don't play polkas with him. When I'm with him he features me on whatever I would like to do. He calls me out and I come out and do 15, 20 minutes, and I'll do songs like "Blue Skies," "Twilight Time" I'll play on the guitar, and I'll do "How High the Moon," Les Paul style. You know people love that. So that's I think the difference, because if you're just going to stay on one path and you're just going to play jazz let's say, you're limited then.

MR: Definitely.

LP: You have to wait for someone to call you for that gig. So that's why I keep changing every — and then I use the different guitars. That's how, if you're going to play with Jimmy I'll bring my 335 or I might bring an acoustic with electric of course on it. And with Keith I bring a Les Paul, and so forth. Oh the Squirrel Nut Zippers, have you ever heard of them?

MR: Yeah. I have their CD.

LP: I did a few concerts with them and that was different too. They did all original songs and I never rehearsed with them and I did one, two, — one was at Roseland, I did a show with them at Roseland, a New Year's Eve party in Washington, DC, I can't think of the name of the place. And they would call me and say, "Come on, we want you on the show." I would listen to the first chorus to hear where the changes went, and I would play very soft. I knew what key they were in, and then now I nailed in. The second chorus I'm right with them.

MR: That's cool.

LP: But I had no idea, because it was all original songs that they did. But it was fun working with them.

MR: Yeah, they're a hoot.

LP: Yeah, I think they must have broken up by now.

MR: Yeah there was a — I forget how many years ago

LP: That swing era —

MR: There seemed to be like this "Swing's Back."

LP Swing's back, right.

MR: It wasn't back for too long.

LP: It wasn't back — you're right. But it was cute though, at Roseland I recall seeing these young kids — I say young kids — young people dancing to jitterbug and things like that and they had the 1940s dresses on and zoot suits and all that stuff, and they were dancing and we're playing up there and oh it was great. But it didn't come back too long like you said. But today of course you have the rap stuff.

MR: Which I assume isn't on your radio.

LP: I can't associate with it. I just can't. To me it's poetry. But the music is a drum beat and a little bit —

MR: It's awful bass heavy too.

LP: And bass heavy. So I don't pay too much attention to it. It's probably good, I can't put it all down because the kids love it, but it's not my thing so if I ever received a call for something like that I would never do it, which I wouldn't though, they wouldn't call me.

MR: Well I don't think they use too much guitar anyway.

LP: No. In some cases they do. Very few.

MR: There's a nice picture here off of your website with Jerry Seinfeld.

LP: Oh that was at the Iridium. He showed up one night. And Bucky was on that night in fact. Les didn't feel good and I called Bucky and Jerry came in and we got together. He was very nice, a very nice man.

MR: Neat. Who were some of the — is there anybody that you haven't worked with that you'd like to?

LP: That I haven't worked with?

MR: That you haven't worked with.

LP: Yeah. Yes, yes. There's quite a few. One, as far as a musician or entertainer.

MR: Yeah. Either or.

LP: It doesn't matter who, either way. Well Clapton, Eric Clapton I never had an opportunity to do anything with him, meaning like either a session or have him sit in. He would be one. And gee there are some singers I would love to, but I can't think of them right now, but there's a few, like Diana Krall is very — k.d. lang.

MR: She's quite unique.

LP: Isn't she? They would be something, because I love backing up people. That's always been my thing is to play behind them and try to make them sound as best as I can do for them. Rickie Lee Jones I played for a few times. You've heard of her?

MR: Yes.

LP: Excellent, excellent singer, excellent. I couldn't believe — I mean she is, and she would do standards but with Rickie you can't play too much. She'll say, "Give me a chord," you give her a chord, she sings maybe a measure and a half and then you can give her another chord. But don't try to play anything in between. She wants to do it with her voice. She was tough to work for but she was a great entertainer, a great singer too.

MR: Yeah. Did she do more sort of rubato, out of time singing?

LP: Yeah. More rubato.

MR: That's tough like when to — you want it now?

LP: A lot of rubato. And a lot of Sinatra stuff. She did a lot of his songs. And I worked with her three times. She was great to work with. So many.

MR: Are you at all into music technology as far as gadgets and computers and all that kind of thing?

LP: No. I see them in the musician's magazine when I get it every month they'll show something that you should get, it's either a drum machine or something for something to do with electronics and I just look at it and say okay, I really don't need it. I tried when synthesizers first came out on guitar I tried that and it was great, you can get the string sound behind you and also the chord changes at the same time, and I said to myself you know I'm a guitar player. I'm going to go back to playing guitar. And the synthesizer is

sitting in the back room now, I have five or six of them, they just sit back there, I just don't use them anymore. I'd rather play guitar.

MR: Right. And plus all of a sudden you find yourself going to a gig and you've got all this gear.

LP: Oh the stuff to carry. I know. And that's what I'm trying to eliminate. You're trying to carry small things.

MR: Yeah, the older you get the smaller your gear becomes.

LP: That's right. That's correct. And I love the gigs like two weeks ago a fellow said, "Just bring an acoustic guitar." And I said wow, I haven't had this in a long time, not even an amp, just an acoustic guitar. Oh that was great. And then there are some where I just bring a small amp and I bring that little, the smallest amp I have.

MR: I love Bucky's, he's got this little —

LP: The Jazz Cat. Or which one?

MR: The Gallien Krueger or something?

LP: Oh he's got — well have you seen the new one? He's got the Jazz Cat now. I have one of those too. It's only 23 pounds, it's a new one, and that's light too and I'll carry that around too. As long as you get the sound that you want. If you're going to play with a big five, six pieces, then it's hard to use a small amp. It's very hard. And I use Bucky on some of my jobs where it's just myself, Bucky and Jerry Bruno. I guess you've heard of Jerry, he plays bass. And we do a few things and I'll use my Epiphone and he uses his guitar, and very small amps we use. Great sound.

MR: Any particular horn players that you enjoyed working with, sax or brass players that really stuck out.

LP: Chuck Mangione sat in with us a couple of times. Oh well of course Doc Severinsen, I played with him. He plays. He's great. That I would say on trumpet. And I'm trying to think of anyone else that — named that we worked with. There are more, I just can't think right now.

MR: Do you get calls to play what I guess we'd call traditional jazz or Dixieland?

LP: Dixieland I've had a few.

MR: Okay.

LP: And that's pretty simple, I might have to bring the banjo out on that.

MR: Oh you're a banjoist too when you need to be.

LP: Yes. Not a great banjo player but enough to get by on the banjo, and the mandolin, I've been on calls for sessions on mandolin which I have to woodshed at least two weeks before the session because it's E A D G, it's like a violin tuning. And I have to go all through that again and I have to start getting my act together on the mandolin. The last session I had was with Bucky, we did an Italian Intermezzo it was called, and we had that

one day and we did a whole CD in one day, and oh I can't think — he plays clarinet, he wrote the charts.

MR: Peplowski?

LP: Yes. Ken Peplowski wrote the charts. And that was pretty tough because it was all written out. And to play the mandolin, now I'm more with the guitar, and someone said, from California, they said why don't you do what they did out in California like behind Dean Martin and all those recordings, a lot of them used guitar tuning. But I said oh jeez I don't want to do that because then it might not sound right. So I kept the mandolin tuning. That's why Bucky always recommends me, because the tuning is a little more high pitched and more like mandolin. But it's tough. I really don't want to do too much of that. It's a lot of work. I had to woodshed for two weeks at least.

MR: Well it's tiny too, isn't it?

LP: It's very tiny. But it's easy to get around. Very easy to get around. And I've tried violin since I play mandolin, and I just can't play violin. It's the same tuning but it's the right hand, very important, the bow.

MR: Anything in the near future that's coming up that you're particularly looking forward to?

LP: Nothing right now.

MR: Except your Monday nights.

LP: Monday nights are always there at the Iridium in New York City. And we just did King University a couple of weeks ago, that was with Les too. I think we're supposed to open up some more House of Blues or do Cleveland again. We did, actually we did Cleveland before they even had the rock & roll Hall of Fame built. And that was — Ray Charles was there, the Les Paul Trio. Then we just had the trio. Gary Mazzaroppi on bass, myself and Les. And they didn't even have the building yet. We did the first where they were getting the money for it, to build. And then we went out and did the rock & roll Hall of Fame a couple of times. And it was different groups now, but went out there. And that's about the only thing. They want us back out there, they want us in Cleveland again for the House of Blues, but of course I don't think Les wants to travel too much now.

MR: Does he live right in —

LP: In Mahwah, New Jersey. Right.

MR: Oh you said that.

LP: Very close by.

MR: All right.

LP: So we'll stick with New York for now, stay in the New York area.

MR: Yeah. Okay. Well it's something to keep making a living in music, that's the way I feel, to have that ability to, as you said, step into one king of gig and then the next night another kind and it also keeps your mind pretty active.

LP: Yes. And you, again, like I said, you never stop learning. I used a sax player with me Wednesday night and I asked, it was Nicki Parrott's sister, she plays alto. And I used her on a gig and she — I said, "Do something in a rumba tempo" and she did it. It was a song I never heard in my life and I forgot the title of it now but I'm going to call her up. Of course I could hear the changes and I just backed her up. But I said, "I never heard that song before." And she said, "Oh you never heard it? Wow." It was unbelievable for me not to hear it, especially, you know, I know almost every song from the 1940s up. And she got me. So I'm going to look that song up.

MR: If someone said, "Let's do 'Misty,' let's do it in B."

LP: No problem.

MR: No problem.

LP: No.

MR: How do you think that? How do you —

LP: Uh, and I'm not going by frets. Let's say if you're playing something right here on here, and someone's going up a full step you just go here. I am not thinking that. Maybe years ago I did, but now I'm thinking of the one four five and so forth and I use the system of knowing the change that's coming. In other words if I'm in the key of C and you're going to bring it to say F, I go a fourth up, a fourth up from there and then I know the change. Or I picture it in the key that I do know it in and I know that I'm going to the five change or to the two minor seven change, it's all there already. It's like a photograph in there or something.

MR: Yeah.

LP: But there are times you can get stuck, because if there are a mess of changes then you say all right well let me just pick out the main ones and you skip one or something in between. But otherwise no problem. But I never do the where you could just cheat, we call it — it's not really cheating, it's like when you put a capo on a guitar. All these people have capos, they're playing the same chord over and over but they're in a different key. Same as Irving Berlin we were talking about with the piano. But, so I just could never do that. I'd rather just change to the key you're supposed to be in. But it's interesting when someone does change a key. It keeps you on your toes.

MR: Definitely.

LP: You have to really think.

MR: Like the women singers are often a fourth or fifth away from where you normally would play it.

LP: And they will go to B. And guitar players love E, we say — not all guitar players — love E, A and D let's say. I hate those keys. Not that I hate them, I'd rather play E flat, it's more for a horn. I like E flat, I like A flat, I love D flat. But E, because I got away from

that open stuff down there many, many years ago and it's hard to me to even play the open chords anymore.

MR: It's almost too easy, huh?

LP: Well I think it's hard. It's hard.

MR: You think that now.

LP: I'd rather play all the different changes up here.

MR: Okay.

LP: It's hard. But that's why I prefer E flat.

MR: Well that puts you in good with most of the classic standards, because the majority of them are in flat keys, right?

LP: Exactly. A flat, B flat, even "Stardust" is written in D flat, as you know. And then when you're on a special gig you have to look over at the person that's going to play it and say are you going to do it in the original or C? A lot of them do it in C.

MR: I see. Okay.

LP: They do it in C. But the original of course is D flat.

MR: The worst is when they can't tell you.

LP: I've been through that too. I've been through that too, where I've asked many players, "What key are we in" and they just looked at me and I'm going wow you're a horn player, but yet sometimes horns are a little different.

MR: Right. Or sometimes they'll say, "My first note is a D."

LP: Yes. I've been through that too.

MR: So you're thinking okay his first note's a D [scats] do it like that, transposing.

LP: I had that case on a job that I did. A fellow came up and said I want to sing "Fly Me To the Moon." So I said, "Well what key do you want it in?" He says, "A." Fine. So I gave him the first note and he sang it and he said, "That's the wrong key." He wanted me to start on A minor seventh. Well A minor, we'll just say A minor, and it would be in the key of C. So I put it in the key of A. So I told him, I said, "Well you told me A." He said, "Oh I, —" He didn't know what key he was in. He just knew he started on A. A what though? A minor? A major? Oh and then you do have people when you have relative minor and major.

MR: That's right.

LP: Now and if you're going to do "My Funny Valentine" what key is it in? Is it in C? E flat or whatever key you want, A flat? Because you're going to start on a minor, a relative minor. They might say A, that means A minor and it's in the key of C. Or E minor, key of G and so forth.

MR: There's a couple of tricky songs like that that they'll end up where they say —

LP: Right and then I feel bad because now I'm saying I hope they can make it.

MR: Yeah.

LP: Hope the first note, this is the right key. And nine out of ten yes, but there are some that really don't know. They don't know. And that's experience. You have a lot of experience and then you just bring it back down.

MR: Yeah.

LP: Bring it to whatever key you think they should be in.

MR: Right.

LP: It might be the wrong key that they even gave you.

MR: Right. I kind of know better than to — yeah that's funny. Well it's nice that you can do that and nice that you care enough to do it.

LP: Oh yes. I'd rather do it that way and get it right.

MR: Well it's been really fascinating talking to you.

LP: Well it's fascinating to talk to you. My God, you made it so nice and comfortable for me.

MR: Well good.

LP: I might just sit right here for the rest of the day.

MR: I hope to get to hear you play sometime.

LP: I hope so. I think we'll keep in touch and if I ever come up your way I'll give you a call.

MR: Definitely.

LP: I promise.

MR: Okay. I hope you make it to the Turning Stone too.

LP: I will. And I thank you very much.